

Field Study → Theory, by Level of Practice

The two Module 4 field studies, each Problem-of-Practice prompt at the Learner / Program / System level, and the HPL theories to bring in at each level. A planning map for your argument — not the argument itself.

00 The assignment, in one box

The **Problem of Practice (PoP)** asks you to choose **one field study** (One Village, One Preschool *or* Road to Success Academy) and respond at **one level of practice** (Learner, Program, or System). Each prompt poses a **decision between two options**; you make and defend an argument, **citing course concepts** from the module (you may draw on earlier modules too).

The three levels = whose vantage point you argue from: **Learner** = frontline, working directly with learners (a teacher / staff member) · **Program** = running the organization (director / manager, partnerships & staff development) · **System** = the wider policy / governance layer (government official / school board).

01 Field Study A — One Village, One Preschool (OVOP)

OVOP · RURAL CHINA

What it is: An initiative expanding access to early-childhood education in remote rural China through **Village Early Education Centers (VEECs)**, run with the **China Development Research Foundation (CDRF)** and, increasingly, local government. It serves young children — many from **migrant-worker families** and the **Miao** and other ethnic-minority groups — aiming to foster relationships, social-emotional development, early literacy, and culturally/linguistically responsive learning.

LEARNER Lead VEEC teacher

You have curricular autonomy. Students feel **disconnected from school** and the academic material. Two promising fixes — and limited prep time means you pick one to prioritize.

Decide: new social-emotional learning lessons vs. new curricular materials integrating students' cultural & linguistic identities.

- ▶ **Social-emotional learning (SEL) & the CASEL competencies** 4.4.2
- ▶ **Relationships & care; trustworthy teachers** — belonging drives engagement 4.1.1 · 4.1.2 · 4.4.1
- ▶ **Culturally responsive / relevant / sustaining pedagogy** — using Miao language & culture as an asset 4.3.3
- ▶ **Attributed vs. internalized learner identity; making school feel "for me"** 4.3.1 · 4.3.2
- ▶ **Funds of knowledge / asset (not deficit) framing** 3.2.1 · 3.2.4
- ▶ **Authentic learning & motivation; ZPD / scaffolding for connection to material** 2.3.3 · 1.4.2

PROGRAM CDRF program director

Two sponsors want to fund one new initiative in a predominantly Miao county; you can engage only one partnership.

Decide: a family-engagement pilot (home visits coaching caregivers on relationships, SEL & early literacy) vs. funding culturally/linguistically responsive curricular materials.

- ▶ Family & community engagement in education; caregivers as partners 4.4.4
- ▶ The lasting importance of early relationships — leveraging caregivers 4.1.1
- ▶ Bonding vs. bridging social ties across home and center 4.4.3
- ▶ Culturally sustaining pedagogy at program scale 4.3.3
- ▶ SEL program design; ERI development support 4.4.2 · 4.2.2
- ▶ Situated learning / communities of practice (teacher capacity) 1.4.3

SYSTEM County education-bureau official

Management of OVOP is transferring from CDRF to the local county government. You help set strategic direction with budget for one pathway.

Decide: expand family-engagement (home-visit early-learning program) vs. standardize the curriculum county-wide (culturally responsive, plus teacher PD).

- ▶ Settings & the ecological model; person-in-activity-in-context at system scale 1.3.4 · 1.4.1
- ▶ Family & community engagement as system strategy 4.4.4
- ▶ Culturally sustaining pedagogy as policy; standardization vs. local responsiveness tension 4.3.3 · 4.3.4
- ▶ Asset vs. deficit framing; equity across the county 3.2.4
- ▶ Cultural difference & "WEIRD" cautions when standardizing 1.2.4 · 3.2.1
- ▶ Teacher learning / professional development (situated learning) 1.4.3

RTSA · LA COUNTY JUVENILE JUSTICE

What it is: An education approach for youth in **U.S. juvenile-justice facilities** (Los Angeles County camps), developed with guidance from HGSE's **Dr. Lynette Tannis**. It emphasizes **healing, relationships, and social-emotional learning** to prepare young people for fulfilling lives beyond the carceral system — a counter to the school-to-prison pipeline. (*Content touches the dehumanization and structural violence of youth incarceration.*)

LEARNER Staff professional at RTSA

New students struggle to adjust and feel part of the community; relationships are among the biggest factors in success. A new initiative helps each student build **one close relationship** on arrival.

Decide: focus that relationship on a peer who has adjusted well vs. a staff member / adult.

- ▶ **Building relationships through care;** trusting & trustworthy adults 4.4.1 · 4.1.2
- ▶ **Bonding vs. bridging skills** — peer vs. adult tie 4.4.3
- ▶ **Peer relationships** & their role in learning 4.1.3
- ▶ **Belonging / psychological safety** as a condition for learning 4.1.1 · 4.1.4
- ▶ **SEL competencies; buffering against toxic stress** in a high-threat setting 4.4.2 · 1.3.1 · 1.3.2
- ▶ **Attributed & internalized learner identity;** countering stigma 4.3.1 · 4.3.2

PROGRAM RTSA program manager

You're planning a quarterly PD "Saturday Summit" on one aspect of SEL: supporting students' **identity development**. Limited time means one focus.

Decide: prioritize identity as learners vs. ethnic-racial identity (ERI) development.

- ▶ **Theories of identity development** (e.g., exploration & resolution) 4.2.1
- ▶ **Ethnic-racial identity (ERI) development;** ERI in action 4.2.2 · 4.2.3
- ▶ **Attributed vs. internalized learner identity;** stereotype threat 4.3.1 · 4.3.2
- ▶ **Culturally responsive / sustaining pedagogy;** ethnic studies as "Precious Knowledge" 4.3.3 · 4.3.4
- ▶ **SEL as the umbrella; staff as a learning community** (psychological safety) 4.4.2 · 4.1.4

SYSTEM Remarks to the LA County school board

Some caregivers worry RTSA over-emphasizes **social-emotional themes** at the expense of **standard academic content**; others see SEL as vital. You prepare board remarks that honor both but defend one position.

Decide: defend prioritizing SEL / healing-centered emphasis vs. standard academic content — for the board's dialogue with caregivers.

- ▶ **Settings & ecological model**; designing the carceral-education system for development 1.3.4 · 1.4.1
- ▶ **Buffering vs. toxic stress / trauma-informed practice** in justice settings 1.3.1 · 1.3.2
- ▶ **Authentic learning & motivation; knowledge as a means to action** (academics in service of agency) 2.3.3 · 2.4.4
- ▶ **Critical consciousness**; education against the school-to-prison pipeline 2.1.4
- ▶ **Culturally sustaining pedagogy & family/community engagement** at system level 4.3.3 · 4.4.4
- ▶ **Asset vs. deficit framing** of incarcerated youth 3.2.4

03 Quick theory × level matrix

LEVEL	LENS YOU ARGUE FROM	GO-TO THEORIES (BOTH FIELD STUDIES)
Learner	Teacher / direct-service staff with one learner or class	Relationships & care (4.1, 4.4.1) · trustworthy teachers (4.1.2) · SEL (4.4.2) · bonding/bridging (4.4.3) · learner identity & stereotype threat (4.3.1–4.3.2) · ZPD/scaffolding (1.4.2) · authentic motivation (2.3.3) · funds of knowledge (3.2.1)
Program	Director / manager — partnerships, PD, program design	Family & community engagement (4.4.4) · identity-development programming (4.2, 4.3) · culturally sustaining pedagogy (4.3.3) · SEL program design (4.4.2) · situated learning / communities of practice & staff psychological safety (1.4.3, 4.1.4) · bonding/bridging social capital (4.4.3)

LEVEL	LENS YOU ARGUE FROM	GO-TO THEORIES (BOTH FIELD STUDIES)
System	Government official / school board — policy & governance	Settings & ecological model (1.3.4, 1.4.1) · culturally sustaining pedagogy as policy & ethnic studies (4.3.3–4.3.4) · asset vs. deficit framing (3.2.4) · WEIRD / cultural difference cautions (1.2.4) · knowledge as action & critical consciousness (2.4.4, 2.1.4) · trauma/buffering (1.3.1–1.3.2)

★ Building your argument

- **Name the tension.** Each prompt is a genuine trade-off — say what each option gains and costs before you choose.
- **Lead with 2–3 theories, not ten.** Pick the concepts that most directly justify your choice; define each in your own words and tie it to the specific scenario.
- **Match the level.** A Learner-level answer talks about *this teacher and these students*; a System-level answer talks about *policy, equity, and scale*. Use evidence appropriate to the vantage point.
- **Acknowledge the other option.** The strongest arguments concede the merits of the path you didn't choose, then explain why your choice wins *for this context*.
- **Cite the module.** Reference Module 4 concepts by name (relationships, identity, SEL, culturally sustaining pedagogy) — and reach back to earlier modules where it strengthens the case.

Academic-integrity note: this is a planning map of the course's concepts to help you reason — the argument, wording, and position must be your own. Check your course's AI-use policy, and disclose assistance if required.